

8.1 First Things First

What follows are some general tips that should be implemented immediately after installing a fresh copy of Windows XP. The purpose of these tips is to boost XP's performance.

8.1.1 Speeding Up The Bootup Process

The common yardstick used to determine system performance is the boot speed. Though this isn't really right, people tend to have a fascination with boot speeds. Let's take a look at some of the common tricks used to speed up the booting process.

1. Disable boot virus detection

Some motherboards come with the capability to scan the boot sector for virus infection. Boot sector viruses were prevalent some years ago, and posed great danger to the hard drive partition table; however, the virus-writing community seems to have given up on this method of attack!

And so, boot virus detection takes up precious boot time and slows down the bootup process. We would advise you to turn off this feature on your motherboard for faster boot speeds. To find out how you can do so, look in the "Advanced BIOS features" section of your BIOS.

2. Change The Boot Sequence

Since Windows XP is generally installed via a CD-ROM, the boot sequence is set to CD-ROM first, and then the hard drive. By realigning the boot sequence, a few seconds can be chopped off the bootup time. Keep your OS-loaded hard drive as the primary boot device; this is generally denoted as "Hard Disk0". Similarly, if, like most people, you hardly use your floppy drive, turn it off from the BIOS. As far as floppy drives are concerned, there is an option to scan the drive on bootup. Turn this feature off to save a couple of more seconds.